

F***k

You, Consumers!

A chilling tale of how cartels were born, and consumers were left out in the cold and the rain

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It was a very still night, calm and peaceful, with only a gentle breeze stirring through the trees. But as I stared over the terrace I couldn't really appreciate the beauty of the place, it was just something noted in passing. The very thought of the weight of responsibility resting on my shoulders was weighing me down. As I looked as the limousines slowly pulling up the driveway, at the hard-faced, somber businessmen and industry leaders that were stepping out and hurrying in, I knew that they too were worried. This was a hard time for all of us; markets were down, margins diminishing, whole product lines vanishing overnight. We needed to do something about this and fast. This was no longer a question of just profits; we had to find a way to survive.

There was hope for us though. I had an idea, a ghost from the past, something that we forgot about in our struggle for supremacy and market share. I had invited them over to convince them of it. It seemed like the only way to ensure our survival, but it was an ambitious plan, requiring cooperation at the highest level. As the last of the cars pulled in, I took in a last whiff of the cold night air, composed myself and went inside to greet my guests.

Nobody was really in a mood for all the niceties and introductions, we knew each other well enough anyway and even if we didn't, such larger than life industrial barons were media magnets and as such, we knew *of* each other. They quickly settled down in the hall, some restlessly pacing the floor, others languidly relaxed on the sofas, outwardly very calm. I requested everyone to sit down, the restless pacing was too distracting. After many years of working in my field, I had gotten the hang of summing up

people at a glance, but the faces of most of these people I couldn't read. That deadpan expression had been honed over the years, giving away nothing. Without further ado I launched into my speech.

“The consumer is like cattle, very special cattle, their milk is priceless but they don't know their own strength, their true value. If we were to tether a calf, that's used to being free, to a stick, it will struggle. It will kick, it will scream, there will be sympathizers who will try to free it. Some calves may escape, there will be fights; it will be a hard time for all of us but we must persevere. Given enough time, enough distractions, the calf will grow up, it will forget that it was ever free and it will accept its situation. We will completely control it and it won't know any better!

This plan was brilliant, it was ideal, the solution to all our problems and we would have had an infinite flow of gold with nothing to prevent us from doing what we liked and we had this in the 1930s.

What did we do wrong? What did we miss? We had started small, the Phoebus cartel had a stranglehold on light bulbs and we managed to bring down their life drastically. It seemed normal to them that a bulb would blow in a few weeks. It never occurred to them that NASA, for



Frankenstein's monster. Our future?